

From Local Enterprise to Wider Recognition: A Journey of Confidence and Growth

This is the story of Shilpa Ji from Shimla, Himachal Pradesh who got married in 2008 and moved to a village. After marriage she realised that the village did not have stable livelihood options, the source of generating income in that village could either take place via owning a business or through daily wage earning activities because that specific location did not have the cash crop opportunities. Seeing the financial status and needs of the family she along with her husband decided to start walking on the path of entrepreneurship in the year 2010. So the decision of becoming an entrepreneur was more of a practical need for Shilpa Ji and her family.

Shilpa Ji and her husband are involved in the business of tents and own an electronics shop as well. Earlier they started operating at small scale across the local village area only, but after joining National Rural Livelihood



Mission (NRLM) in 2014, they were able to expand it outside the village as well. After joining NRLM she started to get various opportunities available for entrepreneurs, she understood the mechanism of the utilisation of the available government schemes for business expansion. Also, she gained much more confidence after interacting with so many people as a result of maintaining business communications. So, NRLM acted as an enabler of business growth.

Both the husband and wife collectively work towards the growth of the business, their respective activities complement each other well. Her husband mainly focuses on the marketing and promotions, She primarily focuses on the store maintenance with a team of people while the field visits and business communication is handled by both of them together.

The entrepreneurial journey brought a transformation in her personal life as well. There was resistance in her village for the women to go out of the houses without asking permission. So, taking risks and starting a business by a woman was a very difficult path to walk. Even Shilpa Ji felt hesitant to go out and interact with people but then her family supported and encouraged her to become an entrepreneur. Gradually she built confidence, felt independence and now she has developed and expanded the business well. The success of the business made people of her village and outside the village change their perceptions and started recognising and giving respect to her. The supportive role played by her family has been an example for others.

Another significant challenge faced by her was the lack of finance for the business for which they used their own savings and bank credit as well. The Financial and Digital Literacy Training helped her a lot in understanding registration related compliances especially for GST, systematic record keeping including cashbook and balancesheet, marketing, packaging and labelling. The training assisted her in understanding about how to sell the products and promote them professionally. She was already using the instagram page and word of mouth for promotion and expansion of the business but after the training she understood how to complement this promotional effort with other significant aspects of the business. She now aspires to participate in more advanced training to strengthen and grow her business in every aspect.

Her journey represents that entrepreneurship can not only help in the economic transformation of a woman but also can bring her confidence and respect within the community. She represents the potential of women to challenge traditional challenges and build sustainable livelihood option.